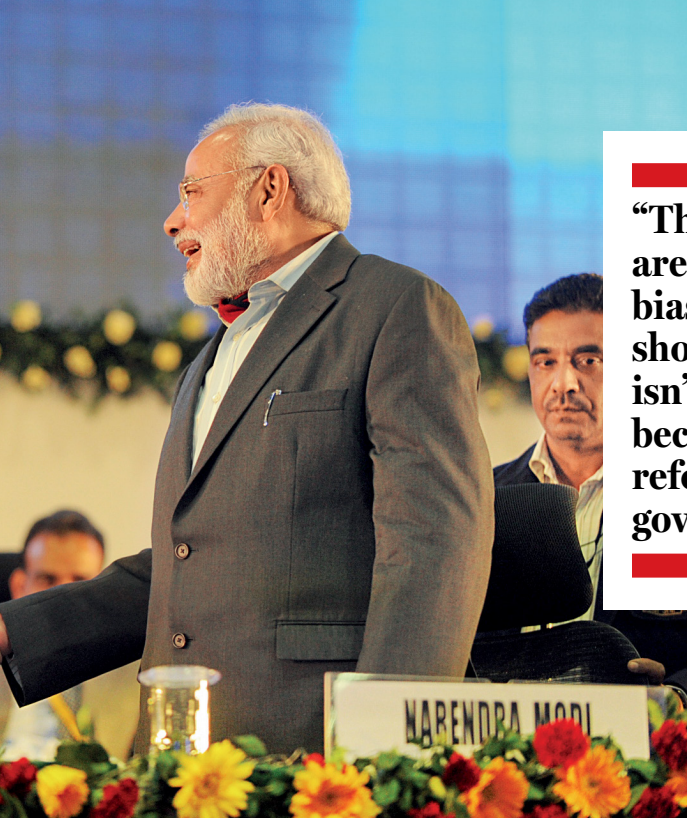


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"The allegations about PM Modi and me are baseless and suffer from a recency bias, seeing our group's success through a short-term lens. My professional success isn't because of any individual leader but because of the policy and institutional reforms initiated by several leaders and governments over three-plus decades"

and determination in the face of adversity? Seeing their story, my belief is further reinforced that there is no machine stronger than the human mind. Such stories are the biggest source of motivation for me.

Q. What is the logic behind the Adani group's expansion, whether in building infrastructure or entry into new areas?
I was born in a middle-class family and I lived through the 1970s and '80s when we had to struggle for *bijli*, *sadak* and *paani*. That was a time when India had a huge infrastructure deficit in ports, airports and other areas. In contrast, China, which also became independent around the same time as India and had a lower per capita income than India in 1990, began leapfrogging ahead of us in development. All these issues instilled a huge desire in me to do whatever I could to transform India, particularly in infrastructure. Meanwhile, starting from 1991, policy changes created an enabling environment for the entry of the private sector in the infrastructure space. This is why I am determined to use every opportunity to build world-class infrastructure and facilities in India.

Q. What is your management style, your mantra for success?
All our businesses are run by professional, competent CEOs. I do not interfere in the day-to-day functioning of the companies. My role is limited to formulating strategy, capital allocation and performance review. It's also why I have the time to not only manage such a large and diverse organisation but also incubate several new businesses and look for new opportunities for acquisitions.

Q. One of the new acquisitions was the takeover of the NDTV media group. Will the same management principle of non-interference that you showed in other group companies follow suit here? How will you ensure its editorial independence?
On editorial independence, let me say categorically that NDTV will be a credible, independent, global news network with a clear *lakshman rekha* between management and editorial. You can endlessly debate and interpret each and every word that I say...as has been done by many...but my fundamental point is that the proof of the pudding is in the eating. So, please allow us some time before you start judging us.

Q. Another concern raised by critics is that the Adani Group is highly overleveraged, that its debt is to the tune of Rs 2 lakh crore. How do you plan to tackle the debt and repay it?
I am greatly surprised by these conversations around our debt. We are financially very strong and secure. Such noises are coming from two sections. The first are people who have not bothered to do a deep-dive to understand the detailed nuances of debt and finances of our companies. I am sure if they make an effort to understand the financial statements, all the misgivings about debt will disappear. Then there is the second category of people with vested interests who are deliberately creating confusion and misunderstanding to tarnish the reputation of the group. The fact is that, in the past nine years, our profits have been growing at twice the rate of our debt, because of which our debt-to-EBITDA (earnings before interest, taxes, depreciation, and amortisation) ratio has come down from 7.6 to 3.2, which is very healthy for a large group where most of the companies are in the infrastructure space with assured and predictable cash flow unlike in manufacturing. This is the reason why not just national, but international rating agencies too have rated us equivalent to India's sovereign rating. It is a matter of great pride for me that no other business group in India has as many companies as the Adani Group which have sovereign ratings. It is these fundamental financial strengths of our group that helped us close the ACC and Ambuja deal in a record time of just three months.

Q. There are also concerns that banks, including public sector banks, have huge exposure to Adani debt. How do you respond